

Animal skeletons

Without a skeleton, most animals would be a shapeless blob. Vertebrates, such as mammals and birds, have a strong internal skeleton. Many invertebrates, such as insects, have a protective external skeleton, called an exoskeleton.

WHAT DOES THE SKELETON DO?

A skeleton provides an animal's body with strength, shape, and protection. Muscles are attached to the bones, and joints between bones enable movement. Bones also store vital minerals and produce red blood cells.



SUPPORT
The skeletal framework gives shape and strength to an animal's body.



PROTECTION
Bones such as the ribcage and skull protect vital organs from injury.



MOVEMENT
Bones act as levers and are points of attachment for the muscles.

INNER SKELETONS

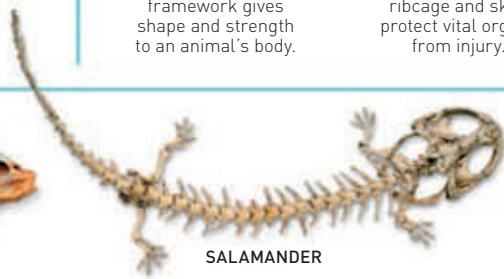
All vertebrates have an inner skeleton that supports the body and protects the organs. The skeleton is usually made of bone, although some animals – such as sharks – have a skeleton made of flexible cartilage.



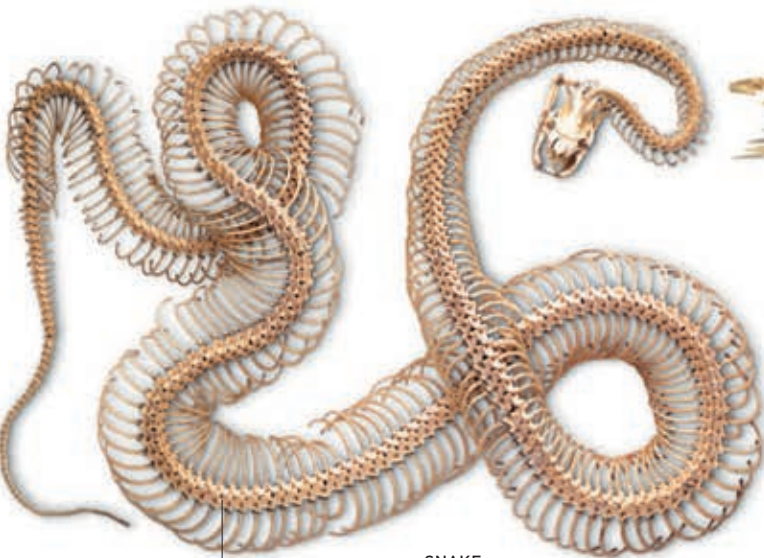
FLATFISH



FISH



SALAMANDER



SNAKE



FROG



TURTLE



TORTOISE



CHAMELEON



GECKO



LIZARD



CAIMAN



PENGUIN



STARLING



CROW



DUCK



PIGEON



BUZZARD



KESTREL



OWL



EAGLE



Long backbone has hundreds of curved ribs attached to it

Flexible backbone extends into a long tail